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POLITICS - Voting implies possible trends - L.A.-area California Assembly elections bring a 'huge moment' for women and a teen candidate

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With women, a teenager and hyperpartisanship in the political spotlight, much about Tuesday's special elections for the California Assembly in parts of Los Angeles County seemed to be ripped from the current headlines.

That's true even if much about the election results felt like old news, with well-funded and well-connected Democratic candidates leading vote counts in L.A. as usual.

The elections, the state's first of 2018 and first of the #MeToo movement, were needed to select replacements for three Assembly members who resigned — including two San Fernando Valley Democrats who quit amid sexual-harassment scandals.

When they were over, political observers said these developments were most notable:

• Women picked up one Assembly seat and appeared on the verge of picking up another. Democrat Sydney Kamlager ran away with the 54th District, in L.A., Culver City and Inglewood, and Democrat Luz Rivas rolled into a runoff against Republican Ricardo Benitez in the heavily

Democratic 39th District, in the northeast San Fernando Valley.

• A 19-year-old Republican named Justin Clark advanced to a runoff by finishing second to Democrat Jesse Gabriel in the 45th District, in the mostly Democratic west San Fernando Valley.

• Far from charmed by the teenager's accomplishment, critics called the strong finish by the Cal State Northridge student and ice cream shop worker a bad sign for democracy.

Women's success is a "huge moment," said Valerie McGinty, founder and president of Fund Her, an organization that raises money to elect progressive women to California state offices.

Analysts thought women would do well but maybe not as well as Kamlager and Rivas did. Kamlager, the L.A. Community College District board president, got 68.9 percent of the votes in the four-person race to replace Democrat Sebastian Ridley-Thomas, who resigned because of health problems; that was far more than the simple majority needed to avoid a runoff. Rivas, an engineer and founder of a Pacoima nonprofit that promotes science and technology education for girls, got 41.9 percent to small businessman Benitez's 22 percent and Democrat Antonio Sanchez's surprisingly weak 18.7 percent in a six-way race to replace Democrat Raul Bocanegra, who resigned after multiple women accused him of sexual harassment.

The disappointment for those aiming to elect more women to the state Legislature was the third-place finish by Democrat Tricia Robbins Kasson, the only female candidate in the 45th District race to replace Matt Dababneh, another assemblyman who quit in the face of sexual misconduct allegations.

Despite that setback, McGinty said Tuesday's results confirm her confidence that women could pick up as many as 10 seats that have been held by men in California's 80-seat Assembly and 40-seat Senate. That would return women's share of the Legislature to the previous high of 30 percent from the current 22 percent.

Jaime Regalado, professor emeritus of political science at Cal State Los Angeles, said the big day for Kamlager and

Rivas “bodes well for women.” Regalado said Kamlager and Rivas are strong candidates who might have been helped by the #MeToo movement and calls for a change of culture in Sacramento after a winter of claims of sexual harassment of women by powerful men.

Rivas said she doesn’t take a victory in the June 5 runoff for granted, but offered a long-range prediction: “It’s on the way to the Legislature being 50 percent women. Little by little, we’ll get there.”

Benitez and Clark were helped to their second-place finishes by the fact they were the only Republicans on the ballots, allowing them to consolidate GOP votes.

But Clark’s success at age 19 was remarkable. While Gabriel, an attorney best known for his role in lawsuits against the Trump administration on behalf of young immigrants, received 32 percent, Clark got 27.1 percent, far ahead of Robbins Kasson (16 percent), Democrat Ankur Patel (10.1 percent), and independent Dennis Zine (8.5 percent), who had quit the race but remained on the ballot. Clark said he was surprised he made the runoff so easily, though not that voters were looking for something different.

“People have put Sacramento on notice that they will not tolerate corruption. They want solutions, not talking points,” Clark said in an interview.

Asked about the activism of teens in favor of gun control following the Parkland, Florida, school shootings, Clark said he disagrees with much of what they support but praised their involvement in the civic process.

“The fact that people are looking up to these kids is a sign that what’s currently there isn’t working,” Clark said. “People are not supporting the status quo. No party has delivered results.”

Campaign consultants for two Democrats decried the support for Clark, who campaigned on a shoestring budget and appeared on the ballot without one of the three-word descriptions that accompany most candidates’ names.

“The upsetting part to me, as a citizen and somebody who cares about the quality of representation we get, is that people would vote for a guy they never heard of and know nothing about,” said Larry Levine, consultant to Robbins Kasson. “Justin Clark may someday have enough of an ideology to deserve that support. But today, even if he had it, the voters didn’t hear it because he basically didn’t campaign. They voted for him because he was in their party.

“This insane partisanship has got to stop. There’s never been a more clear example than this.

Doug Herman, consultant for Sanchez, said Clark’s success betrays “the fallacy of the top-two primary system,” showing that voters pay attention to candidates’ parties just as they did in the days of party primaries.

But Clark said he’s sure he received votes from more than Republicans, noting that only 22.1 percent of District 45 voters are registered with the GOP.

The runoffs June 5 will coincide with the regular state and congressional primaries. In Assembly Districts 39 and 45, voters that day will face both the runoffs and primaries for the next full two-year term involving most of the same candidates who ran Tuesday.

Herman said Sanchez still plans to run for the full term. Levine said Robbins Kasson is considering it. In each case, the candidate would hope to have a better chance with a larger electorate.

With some ballots yet to be counted, turnout for Tuesday’s elections was 8.2 percent of registered voters, reflecting the typically low public interest in special elections.

That’s more old news in an election with plenty that was new.

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